existence in the 1990s. So the size of the right/religious bloc has remained fairly constant for a generation.

The real shift is found within the blocs. In 1981, the two largest parties—Likud and Alignment, a forerunner of Labor—won 95 seats, nearly four-fifths of the Knesset. No other party won more than 5 per cent of the vote. In the last election, though, Labor and the Zionist Union won just 54 seats. If they had agreed to form a unity government, they wouldn't have had a majority. Seven other parties cleared the five per cent mark.

Even more significantly, within the conservative camp, the political spectrum has shifted to the right. The 2015 coalition was the first in decades not to include a single centrist or center-left party, even a small one as a fig leaf. The members of the coalition, particularly from the Likud, were more conservative than in previous years. When journalists from Walla polled the cabinet, just four ministers were willing to publicly endorse the two-state solution, the official policy of the Israeli government (and the Palestinians, and much of the international community). Outsiders often view Netanyahu as a right-wing ideologue; he's actually one of the more liberal members of his own government.

The Israeli electorate, in other words, isn't moving right so much as moving apart. This phenomenon is not unique to Israel: political polarization in the United States, for example, is at its highest level since World War II, a rift caused mostly by the Republican party's hard-right turn. But it is particularly stark here. The "effective number of parties" in the Knesset, a metric based on the number of parties and their shares of the vote, has increased from 3.13 in 1981 to 6.94 today. Compared to European parliaments, only Belgium has a more fractious political system.[1] Not coincidentally, Belgium broke a world record in 2011 for going the longest time without a government.

This is a symptom of the wider polarization in Israeli society, and the growth of narrow tribal identities. Aside from Labor and Likud, each of the parties in the Knesset appeals to a closely-targeted segment of the Israeli electorate: Jewish Home to settlers; Yisrael Beiteinu to Russian emigres; Meretz to leftists in Tel Aviv. Yesh Atid had a lock on the socioeconomic vote in 2013, but two years later it had to compete with Kulanu, which ran on a similar message, albeit calibrated to a narrower audience. "By the second year of a Knesset, the different parties are already beginning to think about how to position themselves," said Yohanan Plesner, the president of